IMO MEPC 84
Meeting Summary

14 May 2026

The 84th meeting of the Marine Environment Protection Committee (MEPC 84) was held from 27 April to 1 May 2026 at the IMO Headquarters in London, supplemented by hybrid (remote) participation.

Group	Subject
WG 1	Air pollution and energy efficiency
WG 2	Reduction of GHG emissions from ships
DG 1	Amendments to mandatory instruments
RG	Ballast water management

Reduction of Greenhouse Gas (GHG) Emissions, Energy Efficiency and other air pollution matters

GHG mid-term measures (IMO Net-Zero framework)

MEPC 84 recalled that draft amendments to MARPOL Annex VI on the IMO Net-Zero Framework (mid-term measures) had been approved at MEPC 83, and that the second extraordinary session of the Marine Environment Protection Committee (MEPC/ES.2), held in October 2025, had not reached agreement and had adjourned for one year following a roll-call-vote, in order to enable further efforts to forge broader consensus, reconcile remaining differences and respond to Member States' concerns. MEPC 84 considered multiple submissions proposing approaches to address outstanding issues and facilitate convergence.

MEPC 84 noted that many delegations expressed continued commitment to achieving consensus on mid-term measures, while discussions revealed significant divergence on key elements of the Framework. Discussions were extensive, with more than 100 interventions made. The views expressed can be summarized as follows:

- Support for maintaining the current framework:
  - IMO Net-Zero Framework was a carefully negotiated and politically viable compromise;
  - Emphasis on maintaining integrity and balance between technical and economic elements;
  - Calls for adoption without reopening core structure;
  - Remaining issues to be addressed through implementing guidelines;
- Concerns regarding feasibility and impact:
  - Framework considered lacking clarity and consensus;
  - Concerns over increased shipping costs and impacts on food and energy security;
  - Reliance on fuels that are not yet available at scale;

   - Risks of non-compliance due to infrastructure and capacity constraints;
- Economic element and fund:
   - Some delegations supported the IMO Net-Zero Fund as essential for equity and transition support;
   - Others opposed levy-based approaches, citing economic burden and uncertainty in revenue use;
   - Divergent views on governance, scope and legal basis (including the need for a separate treaty);
- Alternative approaches proposed by Liberia and co-sponsors:
   - Calls for more pragmatic, evidence-based approaches linked to fuel availability, affordability and scalability;
- Equity and implementation considerations:
   - Emphasis on Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC), flexibility, and support to Small Island Developing States (SIDS) and Least Developed Countries (LDCs);
   - Need to address disproportionately negative impacts, including through funding and cooperation mechanisms;

The timeline was set as follows:

- ISWG-GHG 22: 1 to 4 September 2026;
- ISWG-GHG 23: 23 to 27 November 2026;
- MEPC 85: 30 November to 3 December 2026;
- MEPC/ES.2: 4 December 2026;

Supporting guidelines

While the discussion on the principle of the IMO Net-Zero framework is still pending, MEPC 84 agreed on the following guidelines completed by the Working Group on Air Pollution and Energy Efficiency.

- ***2026 Guidelines for test-bed and onboard measurements of methane (CH_4) and/or nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions from marine diesel engines*** **(MEPC.414(84))**
  MEPC 84 adopted guidelines establishing standardized methodologies for both laboratory and onboard measurement of non-CO_2 greenhouse gas emissions, including procedures for data collection, calibration and reporting, with a view to improving the reliability and comparability of emission data.

  MEPC 84 agreed that methane (CH_4) and nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions may be quantified on a voluntary basis using engine load monitoring or continuous emissions measurement systems, and encouraged further voluntary studies and information sharing.

- ***Guidelines for engine load monitoring (ELM) and calculation of emission values (ELM Guidelines)*** **(MEPC.415(84))**
  MEPC 84 adopted guidelines providing a framework for determining engine load profiles and associated emission factors under actual operating conditions, enabling estimation of emissions based on monitored engine performance and supporting the use of operational data in emission assessments.

- ***Guidelines for continuous emission monitoring systems (CEMS) used to quantify methane (CH_4) and/or nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions from marine diesel engines*** **(MEPC.416(84))**
  MEPC 84 adopted guidelines setting out requirements for the installation, operation, calibration and validation of continuous monitoring systems to ensure accurate, real-time measurement of emissions and to support consistent and transparent reporting.

MEPC 84 noted the progress made by ISWG-GHG 21 on the following guidelines:

- Draft GFI calculation guidelines (base document consolidating proposals, including treatment of energy sources, OCCS, and related parameters);
- Draft amendments to the 2022 Administration verification guidelines to incorporate GFI-related verification requirements; and
- Draft guidance on monitoring, reporting and verification of energy derived from wind propulsion systems (WPS);
- Draft guidelines on Sustainable Fuel Certification Schemes (SFCS), including governance elements and draft terms of reference for a possible SFCS Assessment Group.

Scientific Review of Default Emission Factors (GESAMP-LCA WG) – Ongoing Work

MEPC 84 noted that GESAMP-LCA WG had been established to provide scientific review of proposed default emission factors for well-to-tank (WtT) and tank-to-wake (TtW) emissions, and that a large number of proposals across multiple fuels, particularly LNG and ammonia, had been submitted for assessment. MEPC 84 further noted that significant methodological challenges remain, including incomplete reviews, the need for additional data, and unresolved issues relating to representativeness and conservativeness of emission values, with LNG pathways being particularly sensitive due to variability in upstream emissions and methane slip. In response, MEPC 84 did not endorse final emission factors but instead noted the ongoing work, invited further submissions and data, and deferred completion of the scientific review to future GESAMP-LCA WG meetings, effectively maintaining the issue at a technical review stage without regulatory finalization.

Terms of reference for the Fifth IMO GHG Study

MEPC 84 approved the draft terms of reference for the Fifth IMO GHG Study, covering the period 2018–2025, maintaining consistency with the Fourth Study in terms of scope, granularity and substances covered, while including well-to-wake emissions aligned with the IMO LCA Guidelines. The Study will provide updated inventories, carbon intensity and fuel intensity estimates, as well as business-as-usual emission projections to 2050, based on transparent and replicable methodologies using both top-down and bottom-up approaches, with IMO DCS data as a benchmark. MEPC 84 also agreed to establish a Steering Committee, initiate procurement subject to funding, and proceed towards delivery of the final report to MEPC 87.

EEDI certifications

MEPC 84 adopted the following resolutions:

- **Amendments to *2022 Guidelines on the method of calculation of the attained Energy Efficiency Design Index (EEDI) for new ships* (MEPC.410(84))**
  The amendments extend applicability to dual-fuel engines using non-gas fuels (e.g. methanol, ethanol). From a certification perspective, this removes ambiguity in the treatment of emerging engine and propulsion configurations and ensures consistent calculation and approval of EEDI for such ships.

- ***2026 Guidelines on survey and certification of the Energy Efficiency Design Index* (EEDI) (MEPC.411(84))**
  The guidelines align verification procedures with the updated calculation guidelines.

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CII certification

MEPC 84 adopted or approved the following resolutions and circulars:

- **Amendments *to 2022 Guidelines on operational carbon intensity indicators and the calculation methods (CII Guidelines G1*) (MEPC.412(84))**
  The amendments clarify that the current calculation methodology remains unchanged. In particular, attained CII is to continue using supply-based transport work (capacity × total distance travelled), and the newly introduced DCS granularity (e.g. "underway" and "not underway") is not applied in CII calculations at this stage. From a certification perspective, there is no change to the calculation outcome or verification approach.

- **Amendments to *2024 Guidelines for the development of a Ship Energy Efficiency Management Plan (2024 SEEMP Guidelines)* (MEPC.413(84))**
  The amendments to the SEEMP Guidelines aim to align with the above clarification, specifying that total distance travelled comprises both "underway" and "not underway" distances. The amendments are consequential and do not introduce new requirements. For certification, there is no impact on SEEMP approval or existing documentation. A consolidated text will be circulated as MEPC.1/Circ.925.

- **Revised *interim guidance on the use of biofuels under regulations 26, 27 and 28 of MARPOL Annex VI* (MEPC.1/Circ.905/Rev.1)**
  The revision introduces a change in the calculation of the carbon conversion factor (Cf) for biofuel blends from energy-weighted to mass-weighted averaging. This corrects a methodological inconsistency and may affect CII calculations for ships using blended fuels. The revised guidance applies from 1 January 2027, and will require verification of supporting documentation accordingly.

Onboard Carbon Capture and Storage (OCCS)

MEPC 84 advanced work on the development of a regulatory framework for onboard carbon capture and storage (OCCS), confirming that the matter remains under development. MEPC 84 approved a revised work plan for the development of the OCCS regulatory framework and re-established the Correspondence Group on Measurement and Verification of Non-CO_2 GHG Emissions and Onboard Carbon Capture and Storage to continue technical work and report to MEPC 86.

MEPC 84 agreed that any OCCS concept involving direct or indirect disposal of CO_2 into the sea should be evaluated through the appropriate international frameworks, including the London Convention and London Protocol (LC/LP), using relevant scientific expertise. This confirms that the assessment of marine disposal aspects will not be addressed solely within MEPC.

The re-established Correspondence Group was tasked with further developing methodologies for the measurement and verification of methane (CH_4) and nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions, ensuring alignment with the 2024 LCA Guidelines, and advancing the development of the OCCS regulatory framework. This includes work on accounting, verification and certification methodologies for OCCS, based on existing IMO frameworks and relevant submissions.

Overall, MEPC 84 confirmed that OCCS remains at a technical development stage, with key elements of the regulatory framework, including measurement, verification and environmental safeguards, still under consideration. Further progress is expected through intersessional work, with outcomes to be considered at MEPC 86.

Other MARPOL Annex VI issues

MEPC 84 adopted the following amendments for entry into force on 1 September 2027:

- **Amendments to MARPOL Annex VI (clarification of entries in data reporting required by regulations 27 and 28, accessibility to the IMO Ship Fuel Oil Consumption Database, and review clause of the short-term GHG reduction measure) (MEPC.407(84))**

  Regulation 27 requires ships to collect and report annual fuel oil consumption data to the Administration under the IMO Data Collection System (DCS), while regulation 28 establishes the operational carbon intensity (CII) framework, including calculation, rating and reporting.

  MEPC 84 adopted amendments to regulation 27, clarifying entries in DCS reporting and revising provisions on access to the IMO Ship Fuel Oil Consumption Database. The amendments provide that Parties shall have access to a non-anonymized database for analysis, while allowing an Administration to require its explicit approval before data of ships entitled to fly its flag are included in such database. In this regard, MEPC 85 will consider proposed amendments to the DCS database management guidelines.

  The amendments also include updates to the reporting format and entries, including clarification of reporting periods for regulations 27 and 28 and terminology adjustments, as well as provisions confirming that the CII framework remains subject to review.

- **Special area - North-East Atlantic Ocean**

  MEPC 84 adopted amendments designating the North-East Atlantic Ocean as an Emission Control Area (ECA) for sulphur oxides (SOx), particulate matter (PM), and nitrogen oxides (NOx), pursuant to regulations 13 and 14 and appendix VII of MARPOL Annex VI.

  While the revised amendments will legally enter into force on 1 September 2027, the actual requirements for ships operating in the ECA will apply as follows:

  - for which the building contract is placed on or after 1 January 2027; or
  - in the absence of a building contract, the keels of which are laid or which are at a similar stage of construction on or after 1 July 2027; or
  - the delivery of which is on or after 1 January 2031.

  SOx control (use of fuel oil with sulphur content not exceeding 0.10% m/m) has a period of grace until 1 September 2028.

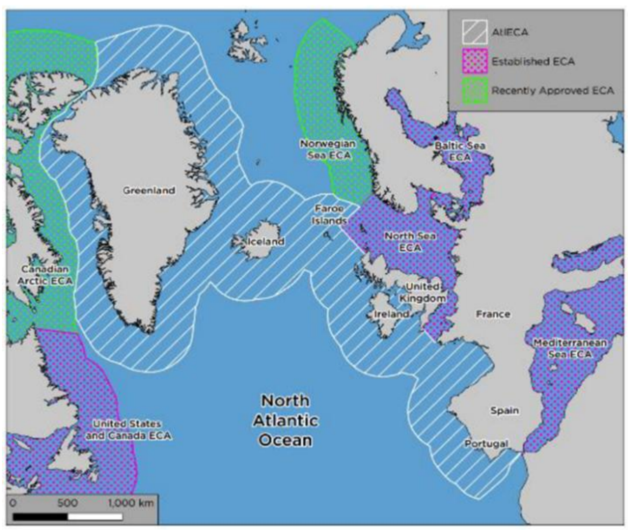

Figure 1: Proposed North-East Atlantic Emission Control Area alongside the other established and proposed ECAs

Figures reproduced from document MEPC 83/12

- **Multiple engine operational profiles**
  MEPC 84 adopted amendments to MARPOL Annex VI by resolution MEPC.408(84), concerning the use of multiple engine operational profiles for marine diesel engines, including clarifying engine test cycles, in alignment with recent amendments to the NO_x Technical Code 2008 adopted by resolution MEPC.397(83).

  - **Regulation 2 (Definitions)**
    The definition of "irrational emission control strategy" is revised to cover any strategy or measure that reduces the effectiveness of an emission control system when a marine diesel engine is operated under normal conditions of use.
  - **Appendix II (Test cycles and weighting factors)**
    The appendix is replaced in full, specifying the applicable test cycles (E2, E3, D2 and C1) depending on engine type and operational characteristics, together with associated weighting factors and conditions for permissible exceedance at certain load points during certification.
  - **Appendix I (Supplement to the IAPP Certificate)**
    New entries are introduced to record engines certified under multiple engine operational profiles (NTC 8) across Tier I, Tier II and Tier III.
  - **Overall effect**
    The amendments align certification practice with the NO_x Technical Code 2008 and actual engine operation, without changing emission limit values.

Implementation of the 0.50% Sulphur Limit – EGCS Discharge Water

MEPC 84 noted information on the use of Exhaust Gas Cleaning Systems (EGCS) as an equivalent means of compliance under regulation 4.2 of MARPOL Annex VI, including outcomes of sulphur monitoring activities conducted in 2025 and updates to the Global Integrated Shipping Information System (GISIS) MARPOL Annex VI module. MEPC 84 invited Member States to submit information on local and regional restrictions or conditions relating to EGCS discharge water through the dedicated GISIS module, including restrictions applicable within ports or terminal areas.

MEPC 84 noted that the Joint Group of Experts on the Scientific Aspects of Marine Environmental Protection (GESAMP) Task Team on EGCS had been re-established, but that its work remained limited to virtual meetings due to insufficient financial contributions. Member States and organizations were encouraged to provide further contributions to support completion of this work.

MEPC 84 concurred with the recommendation that Member States considering proposals for designation of Particularly Sensitive Sea Areas (PSSAs) should assess whether associated protective measures relating to EGCS discharge water may be relevant. MEPC 84 also noted the invitation for further intersessional work and submission of proposals to the Sub-Committee on Pollution Prevention and Response (PPR 14) concerning measures to control EGCS discharge water. In addition, a proposal on a technology-neutral and goal-based approach to the regulation of EGCS discharge water was referred to PPR 14 for further consideration.

MEPC 84 agreed to extend the target completion year for the output on evaluation and harmonization of rules and guidance relating to EGCS discharge water to 2027.

Shipboard incinerator and application date for major conversion in ECAs

MEPC 84 approved revised unified interpretations under MARPOL Annex VI (MEPC.1/Circ.795/Rev.10)

- The interpretation clarifies that the requirement for shipboard incinerators to reach 600°C within five minutes of start-up is a design approval requirement verified during type approval testing, and not an operational performance requirement to be demonstrated during normal onboard use. The amendments further clarify that onboard temperature monitoring systems are intended to support safe operation, but do not serve as evidence of compliance with the design requirement.
- The circular also introduces a unified interpretation regarding the application date for a major conversion in relation to an emission control area (ECA) under regulation 13, clarifying that the applicable date is to be determined consistently with MARPOL Convention practice, taking into account building contract date, keel-laying date, or delivery date, rather than relying solely on keel-laying date.

Volatile organic compounds (VOC) emissions

MEPC 84 approved draft amendments to regulation 15 of MARPOL Annex VI, subject to subsequent adoption, developed by PPR 13, to require new crude oil tankers to be fitted with pressure/vacuum (P/V) valves with a minimum opening pressure of 0.20 bar in order to reduce VOC emissions. The draft amendments also include consequential changes to appendix I (Form of the International Air Pollution Prevention (IAPP) Certificate).

Draft amendments to the NOx Technical Code 2008 – non-carbon fuel

MEPC 84 approved the draft amendments to the NOx Technical Code 2008 for subsequent adoption, to enable certification of engines operating on non-carbon-containing fuels or fuel mixtures. The amendments introduce hydrogen-balance and oxygen-balance methods to complement the existing carbon-balance approach, update relevant chapters and appendices of the Code, and incorporate the default u_{gas} coefficient (ratio of exhaust component and exhaust gas densities) for ammonia and hydrogen, with clarification on their applicability to certain fuel mixtures.

Decisions of other IMO bodies

Protection of the Marine Environment in the Arabian Sea, Sea of Oman and the Gulf Area, including the Strait of Hormuz

MEPC 84 considered the outcome of C/ES.36 regarding the situation in the Arabian Sea, Sea of Oman and the Gulf region, including draft resolutions addressing maritime safety, security, and protection of the marine environment. Divergent views were expressed on the appropriate approach, with some delegations emphasizing the need to address risks to shipping, seafarers, navigation, and the marine environment, while others stressed the importance of maintaining the technical and non-political character of IMO and focusing on cooperation, de-escalation, and pollution response preparedness. Procedural concerns were also raised regarding the handling and timing of certain submissions.

After intense discussion, MEPC 84 adopted MEPC.406(84) on *Actions to ensure the Protection of the Marine Environment in the Arabian Sea, Sea of Oman and the Gulf region, particularly in and around the Strait of Hormuz*. Key elements of the resolution are:

1 Maritime safety and environmental protection

- Recognition of risks to shipping, seafarers, navigation, and the marine environment arising from incidents affecting vessels and infrastructure;
- Recognition of the environmental sensitivity and vulnerability of the Gulf region;

2 Prevention and de-escalation

- Calls for avoidance of actions that may endanger ships, ports, coastal infrastructure, or safe navigation;
- Emphasis on the importance of maintaining safe and uninterrupted maritime traffic;

3 Pollution preparedness and response

- Encouragement to Member States and organizations to strengthen pollution preparedness and response arrangements under MARPOL and OPRC;
- Call to review contingency arrangements for major pollution incidents;

4 Information and reporting

- Invitation to provide information on incidents, impacts on ships and seafarers, and response needs;

5 Institutional follow-up

- Invitation to the Council to consider the matter further;
- Request to the Secretary-General to continue monitoring developments and report as appropriate;
- Decision to keep the matter under review.

Ballast water management

Work arrangements at MEPC 84

MEPC 84 referred almost all ballast water agenda items to the Ballast Water Review Group (BWRG) for detailed work, covering the full BWM Convention review package including amendments to the Convention, revised G4 Guidelines, and further development of the BWMS Code, while excluding only active substances approvals and BWMS type approval matters; effectively, substantive progress and technical decisions are delegated to BWRG, with MEPC 84 retaining only high-level oversight.

BWM Convention review

Draft amendments to the BWM Convention

Following the discussion in the BWRG, MEPC 84 approved the draft amendments to the BWM Convention, as finalized by the Ballast Water Review Group, based on the Correspondence Group package, without substantive changes.

MEPC 84 considered additional proposals, including:

- a proposal to amend regulation A-3 to address exceptional uptake of untreated ballast water during undocking; and
- a proposal to amend regulation E-1 regarding the testing period prior to transition from regulation D-4 to D-2;

and agreed not to amend either regulation, maintaining the text as agreed by the Correspondence Group.

MEPC 84 further agreed that:

- issues related to undocking uptake should be addressed through guidelines rather than Convention amendments; and
- outstanding technical matters related to the BWMS Code should be taken forward by the Correspondence Group.

MEPC 84 requested the Secretariat to prepare a consolidated revised Annex to the Convention for adoption at a future session.

The key changes prepared to the BWM Convention were as follows:

- **Regulation B-1 (Ballast Water Management Plan)**
  Amended to require identification of whether any installed BWMS is type approved under the BWMS Code, approved under earlier Guidelines, or operated under regulation D-4; to introduce requirements for procedures on contingency measures, safe ballast water exchange (including partially treated or non-neutralized water), and, where applicable, temporary storage of treated sewage or grey water in ballast tanks; and to require that changes to the mandatory provisions of the Plan be approved by the Administration, with a version history maintained.
- **Regulation E-1 (Surveys)**
  Amended to introduce an additional survey requirement when a ship transitions from regulation D-4 to D-2, including provisions allowing the commissioning test to be waived where an equivalent test has been successfully conducted within the previous 12 months, and to define how the installation date of the BWMS is to be recorded on the certificate.
- **Appendix I (Form of the International Ballast Water Management Certificate)**
  Amended to include additional information on ballast water management methods used, including system type, installation date, manufacturer details and type approval information, without introducing a separate supplement.
- **Appendix II (Ballast Water Record Book)**
  Amended to introduce a standardized Ballast Water Management System maintenance log, covering both planned and unplanned maintenance activities, to be used where no equivalent recording system is available. Additional amendments to Appendix II were approved, clarifying that the 'final total quantity' is the aggregated volume of ballast water remaining in all ballast water tanks on board. Consequently, updates to BWM.2/Circ.80/Rev.1 to reflect the 'final total quantity' were agreed to be included in the updated list of provisions and instruments for revision in the work of the Correspondence Group.

2026 *Guidelines for ballast water management and development of ballast water management plans* (G4) (MEPC.409(84))

MEPC 84 adopted the revised Guidelines (G4), aligning the content and structure of ballast water management plans (BWMPs) with the amended provisions of regulation B-1 and related instruments.

Key changes include:

- **Alignment with amended regulation B-1**
  BWMPs are required to identify whether installed BWMS are type approved under the BWMS Code, approved under earlier Guidelines, or operated under regulation D-4;
- **Expanded operational procedures**
  Inclusion of procedures for contingency measures, safe ballast water exchange (including partially treated or non-neutralized ballast water), and, where applicable, temporary storage of treated sewage or grey water in ballast tanks;

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- **Operation and maintenance information**
  Requirement to include high-level information on operation and maintenance procedures, with reference to the operation, maintenance and safety manual (OMSM);
- **Consistency of terminology**
  Revisions to ensure consistent use of IMO terminology, including alignment of references to BWMS and related systems;
- **Updated structure and format of BWMP**
  Revisions to the standard format of the Plan to improve clarity and consistency with mandatory Convention requirements.

Unified interpretation to regulation D-3 of the BWM Convention (BWM.2/Circ.66/Rev.6)

MEPC 84 approved a unified interpretation to regulation D-3 of the BWM Convention and agreed to include it in a further revision of the MEPC.2 Circular on provisional categorization of liquid substances (BWM.2/Circ.66/Rev.6).

The unified interpretation clarifies the application of regulation D-3 (approval requirements for ballast water management systems) in specific cases, ensuring consistent understanding and implementation by Administrations and recognized organizations.

Challenging Water Quality (CWQ) Guidance

MEPC 84 noted the lack of support for the adoption of revised Interim guidance on the application of the BWM Convention to ships operating in challenging water quality conditions at this session, and noted that interested Member States and international organizations might work together intersessionally with a view to submitting relevant proposals to a future session.

Contingency Measures under the BWM Convention

MEPC 84 noted the lack of support for the adoption of revised *Guidance on contingency measures under the BWM Convention* at this session, and encouraged port States to work together with flag States and ships to identify the most appropriate contingency measure in situations where a ship has been unable to manage its ballast water.

IMO type approval issues of Ballast Water Management Systems (BWMS) that use active substances

BWMS approvals

IMO - Final approval

- Blue Ocean Shield Electrolytic Chlorination (EC) ballast water management system

Flag State approval in accordance with the BWM Code

MEPC 84 noted that the following system was approved:

- OceanGuard Sim BWMS (New) (Denmark);
- Optimarin Ballast System (Amended) (Norway);
- PureBallast 3.5 Ultra BWMS (New) (Norway);
- BlueBallast II NK-O3 BWMS (New) (Liberia);

- Senza BWMS TG2 (Amended) (Norway);
- Cyeco BWMS (Amended) (Norway); and
- inTank BWTS (Amended) (Norway).

Plastic litters

IMO Strategy to address marine plastic litter from ships

MEPC 84 adopted the resolution MEPC.417(84) on *2026 Strategy and the Action Plan to Address Marine Plastic Litter from Shi*ps, consolidating the existing Strategy and the 2025 Action Plan into a single framework, with both instruments retained as separate annexes.

The Strategy sets out the overall objectives, guiding principles and priority areas for addressing marine plastic litter from ships, including implementation of MARPOL Annex V, port reception facilities, enforcement, cooperation and capacity-building. The Action Plan provides the implementation framework, identifying specific actions, responsible actors and time frames to support delivery of the Strategy.

The revised framework removes outdated timelines and duplicative elements, and provides for a full review of both the Strategy and the Action Plan in 2030 to assess effectiveness and update measures as necessary.

Plastic pellets

MEPC 84 noted that PPR 13 had agreed to the development of a new mandatory code on the carriage of plastic pellets based on MEPC.1/Circ.909 and instructed the PPR Sub-Committee to develop and finalize the draft text of the proposed code and the associated consequential amendments, with a view to taking a final decision on the mandatory instrument (MARPOL Annex III, SOLAS, or both) upon completion of the code.

MEPC 84 noted that some delegations expressed the view that proceeding with mandatory regulations would be premature and that further experience should be gained with MEPC.1/Circ.909, and that deliberations should be deferred pending the outcome of the CCC Sub-Committee on potential amendments to the IMSBC Code. MEPC 84 also noted that some delegations considered that an impact assessment was necessary prior to proceeding.

MEPC 84, however, noted that many delegations opposed conducting an impact assessment at this stage, recalling that relevant procedures provide for assessment of capacity-building implications at the adoption, and agreed to proceed with the development of the mandatory code while deferring both the impact assessment and the final decision on the mandatory instrument.

Fishing gear

MEPC 84 approved MEPC.1/Circ.923 on *implementation of fishing gear marking systems* prepared by PPR 13 and noted the FAO update on related support activities.

Reporting of lost fishing gear

MEPC 84 considered proposals on voluntary reporting of lost fishing gear and related recommendations, and agreed to forward the documents to PPR 14 for further consideration.

Underwater noise

MEPC 84 recalled that MEPC 82 had approved the URN Action Plan and initiated a three-year experience-building phase (EBP) for the application of the Revised URN Guidelines (MEPC.1/Circ.906/Rev.1), supported by dedicated guidance (MEPC 82/17, annex 9) and a structured work programme across SDC and MEPC. The EBP was intended to gather practical experience before considering policy decisions, with a possible extension of up to two years to be assessed based on progress.

MEPC 84 noted general support for extending the EBP and advancing technical outputs, including the proposed IMO-commissioned study, subject to resource considerations. Diverging views were expressed on initiating a policy roadmap at this stage, with many delegations supporting early strategic direction, while others opposed moving to policy development before completion of the EBP, citing concerns on practicality, capacity-building, cost, and potential trade-offs with energy efficiency. MEPC 84 agreed in principle to extend the EBP to 2028, proceed with preparatory work for the study, subject to further review at MEPC 85, and invited further submissions on the appropriate way forward, maintaining the issue under continued consideration.

Technical guidance on co-optimizing energy efficiency and underwater radiated noise (MEPC.1/Circ.922)

MEPC 84 approved MEPC.1/Circ.924 on *Technical guidance on co-optimizing energy efficiency and underwater radiated noise (URN) at the design and retrofit stage*, providing non-mandatory guidance to support the simultaneous consideration of energy efficiency measures and URN reduction in ship design and retrofitting, including identification of potential trade-offs and synergies between measures, with a view to promoting integrated solutions without adversely affecting either objective.

Special areas

Nasca Ridge National Reserve and the Grau Tropical Sea National Reserve

MEPC 83 had agreed in principle to the designation of the two National Reserves as PSSAs, subject to the further development and approval of the proposed associated protective measures.

MEPC 84 considered the proposals for associated protective measures for the Nasca Ridge National Reserve PSSA, including a prohibition on ballast water exchange and discharge under the BWM Convention and designation as a Special Area under MARPOL Annexes I, II, IV and V, noting broad support alongside concerns on proportionality, consistency and operational impacts; the Committee referred the ballast water proposal to the Ballast Water Review Group, which recommended further refinement, and subsequently referred both proposals for further technical development and consideration (to PPR 14 in the case of the MARPOL Special Area), with a view to advising a future MEPC session on how to proceed.

Measures to minimize whale ship strikes

MEPC 84 noted proposals to review the adequacy and effectiveness of existing measures, including possible revision of *the Guidelines for minimizing the risk of ship strikes with cetaceans* (MEPC.1/Circ.674), invited further submissions, including potential new output proposals to a future session, and noted discussion on the use of S-100-based navigational warnings (S-124) within ECDIS to help mitigate ship strike risks.

Oil and Chemicals

Carriage of chemicals in bulk

MEPC 83 endorsed MEPC.2/Circ.31/ on *Provisional categorization of liquid substances in accordance with MARPOL Annex II and the IBC Code,* which took effect on 1 January 2026.

IBTS Guidelines

MEPC 84 approved draft amendments to MARPOL Annex I introducing new regulation 12B on integrated bilge water treatment systems (IBTS) for subsequent adoption by MEPC 85, and also approved in principle the associated 2026 IBTS Guidelines and revised Oil Record Book guidance, with a view to final approval at MEPC 85.

Carriage of cargo oil in the slop tank(s) of an oil tanker

MEPC 84 noted that, in the absence of specific MARPOL Annex I provisions on the carriage of cargo oil in slop tanks, PPR 13 encouraged Member States to develop a common understanding or consider proposing a unified interpretation or a new output.

Others

Biofouling

MEPC 84 agreed that the legally binding framework on ships' biofouling should be developed as a standalone instrument and approved the terms of reference for this work, as updated by PPR 13.

Ship recycling

MEPC 84 noted updates on the interaction between the Hong Kong and Basel Conventions, including outcomes of BC COP-17 and related EU developments, and requested the Secretariat to continue cooperation with the Basel Convention Secretariat and report further developments, including the outcome of the Basel Open-ended Working Group, to MEPC 85.

R&D forum on alternative fuel pollution response

MEPC 84 noted information on a two-day R&D forum in Singapore (September 2026) on preparedness and response to pollution incidents involving alternative fuels.

Further information

For further information please contact: imo@liscr.com

Annex

Provisional list of adopted/approved resolutions/circulars

ID	Title
MEPC.406(84)	Actions to ensure the protection of the marine environment in the Arabian Sea, Sea of Oman and the Gulf region, particularly in and around the Strait of Hormuz
MEPC.407(84)	Amendments to MARPOL Annex VI (clarification of entries in data reporting required by regulations 27 and 28, designation of the North-East Atlantic as an emission control area for nitrogen oxides, sulphur oxides and particulate matter, accessibility to the IMO ship fuel oil consumption database, and review clause of the short-term GHG reduction measure)
MEPC.408(84)	Amendments to MARPOL Annex VI (use of multiple engine operational profiles for a marine diesel engine, including clarifying engine test cycles)
MEPC.409(84)	2026 Guidelines for ballast water management and development of ballast water management plans (G4)
MEPC.410(84)	Amendments to the 2022 Guidelines on the method of calculation of the attained energy efficiency design index (EEDI) for new ships
MEPC.411(84)	2026 Guidelines on survey and certification of the energy efficiency design index (EEDI)
MEPC.412(84)	Amendments to the 2022 Guidelines on operational carbon intensity indicators and the calculation methods (CII Guidelines G1)
MEPC.413(84)	Amendments to the 2024 Guidelines for the development of a ship energy efficiency management plan (2024 SEEMP Guidelines)
MEPC.414(84)	2026 Guidelines for test-bed and onboard measurements of methane (CH_4) and/or nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions from marine diesel engines
MEPC.415(84)	Guidelines for engine load monitoring (ELM) and calculation of emission values (ELM Guidelines)
MEPC.416(84)	Guidelines for continuous emission monitoring systems (CEMS) used to quantify methane (CH_4) and/or nitrous oxide (N_2O) emissions from marine diesel engines
MEPC.417(84)	2026 Strategy and the Action Plan to address marine plastic litter from ships
FAL-LEG-MEPC-MSC.1/Circ.1	Joint guidelines for the use of electronic certificates
MSC-MEPC.2/Circ.15/Rev.3	Guidelines for the development, review and validation of model courses
BWM.2/Circ.66/Rev.6	Unified interpretations to the BWM Convention
MEPC.1/Circ.795/Rev.10	Unified interpretation of regulations 13.2.2 and 13.2.3 of MARPOL Annex VI Unified interpretation of regulation 16.9 of MARPOL Annex VI
MEPC.1/Circ.905/Rev.1	Revised interim guidance on the use of biofuels under regulations 26, 27 and 28 of MARPOL Annex VI
MEPC.1/Circ.923	Implementation of fishing gear marking systems
MEPC.1/Circ.924	Technical guidance on co-optimizing energy efficiency and underwater radiated noise at the design and retrofit stage
MEPC.1/Circ.925	Guidelines for the Development of a Ship Energy Efficiency Management Plan (2024 SEEMP Guidelines)
PPR.1/Circ.10/Rev.1	Resubmission of products listed in lists 2 and 3 of the MEPC.2 circular on provisional categorization of liquid substances in accordance with MARPOL Annex II and the IBC Code
MSC-MEPC.5/Circ.17	Guidance on assessments and applications of remote surveys, ISM Code audits and ISPS Code verifications
MSC-MEPC.5/Circ.3/Rev.1	Unified interpretation of the date of completion of the survey and verification on which the certificates are based
MSC-MEPC.5/Circ.5/Rev.7	Organization and method of work of the Maritime Safety Committee and the Marine Environment Protection Committee and their subsidiary bodies